

CHAPTER 13 — The Decoy

Zoe turned in her seat.

Not towards the mirror this time. Towards Elias himself.

Roadworks had reduced four lanes to two, bringing the traffic to a standstill beneath a row of red gantry signals.

"Jackie came to the house on Sunday," she said. "That was when we made the plan. And when I put her where they could reach her."

The queue began to move.

Elias eased the car forward with it.

"Tell me what happened," he said.

Jackie arrived at twenty past ten on Sunday morning with a supermarket bag in one hand and two phones in the other.

One was hers. The second was an old pay-as-you-go handset with a charger looped around it.

Helen opened the front door only as far as the chain allowed.

"You cannot be here."

"Good morning to you too."

"Jackie, please. This is not a good time."

"It hasn't been a good time since Tuesday."

Helen glanced towards the road.

Jackie followed the movement with her eyes, then looked back at her.

"I've called Zoe thirty-seven times. I've messaged her on everything except the calculator app. School says family emergency. Brian says she's away. You say nothing. So either she's in there, or something's happened and nobody thinks I deserve to know which."

"Go home."

Jackie planted one trainer against the step before Helen could close the door.

She was smaller than Helen and half her weight, but years of holding doors open with a hip while carrying shopping, washing or a sleeping child had made her difficult to move once she decided where she belonged.

"Let me hear her say it."

Helen's face tightened.

"Say what?"

"That she doesn't want to see me."

Zoe had been standing halfway down the stairs, listening.

She came into the hallway before Helen could answer.

Jackie saw her.

For a moment, all the sharpness went out of her.

The supermarket bag slipped against her leg. Her mouth opened, but no sound came.

Zoe had expected questions. She had expected Jackie to cross the hall and touch her face, or demand to know where she had been, or begin talking too fast in the way she did when fear had nowhere else to go.

Instead Jackie said, very quietly, "Purple penguin."

It was nonsense to anyone else.

During their first month as friends, they had invented a way to prove it was really them online. One used the challenge phrase. The other had to answer with the deliberately incorrect response they had fixed years earlier.

Zoe swallowed.

"Green giraffe."

Jackie's shoulders dropped.

Helen looked between them, then removed the chain.

Jackie crossed the hallway and wrapped both arms around Zoe.

She did not squeeze too hard. She did not ask whether Zoe was all right when the answer was visible.

She simply held on.

"One hour," Helen said. "Then you leave. You don't call anyone, you don't post anything, and you do not tell anyone Zoe is here."

Jackie looked over Zoe's shoulder at her.

"Why?"

"Because the people who took her may still be looking."

Jackie's eyes returned to Zoe.

The fear in them lasted less than a second before she put it somewhere else.

"Fine," she said. "One hour."

Neither girl believed her.

Jackie had brought food.

Not only sweets or crisps, though there were both buried near the bottom of the bag. She had brought bread rolls, sliced cheese, two apples, a packet of biscuits, bottled water and a small container of pasta she had made the night before.

"You look like you've been living on air," she said when they reached Zoe's room.

"Toast."

"Luxury."

She locked the door, tested the handle, then pushed the desk chair beneath it even though the chair would not have stopped anybody determined enough to enter.

Zoe watched her divide the food without thinking: one roll for now, one

wrapped for later; water opened first; apple kept until Zoe had eaten something heavier.

Jackie had been arranging meals for people since before either of them understood that children were not supposed to be responsible for feeding whole households.

Her mother had died when she was six.

At first Jackie had done only what a six-year-old could do. Cereal poured into bowls. A bottle warmed too long. Her four-year-old sister's hair dragged into an uneven ponytail. The baby changed with so much talcum powder that the room looked as though it had snowed.

Then her father's drinking grew worse, and the jobs grew with it.

Laundry. School lunches. PE kits. Permission slips. Dinners made from whatever remained in the cupboard. Keeping two sisters and a little brother quiet when their father came home angry, then waking them early enough to hide what had happened before school.

By the time Jackie was ten, she could run a house better than most adults.

Then the children had been taken.

Not together.

Jackie had been sent to one placement, her sisters to two others and her brother somewhere nobody would name. She had not seen any of them since.

She spoke about them rarely. When she did, she used the present tense.

My sister hates peas.

My brother sleeps with one foot outside the blanket.

Never used to. Never did.

Zoe had understood early that this was one of the rules of loving Jackie: the missing were not to be treated as dead simply because the adults responsible for them found disappearance more convenient.

Jackie placed the pasta container in Zoe's lap.

"Eat."

"You sound like Helen."

"Rude. I season food."

The joke was ordinary enough that Zoe almost cried.

Jackie saw it coming and looked away, pretending to inspect the shelf above the desk.

"Your ceramic mask still looks haunted," she said.

"It's a mask."

"It's a cry for help."

Zoe laughed once. The sound came out wrong, but it came.

For the first time since the van door had closed, she was with somebody who did not need her to explain who she had been before it happened.

She told Jackie everything.

Not in order.

The locked bedroom came before the van. The older girl came before Cain. The showing broke apart halfway through because Zoe could not describe the room and remain inside her own body at the same time.

Jackie never told her to slow down.

She asked practical questions.

How many doors between the bedroom and the stairs?

Did the windows open?

Had anyone used Zoe's name before she gave it?

Did Cain's people know about Helen and Brian?

Had Zoe seen the same men more than once?

The questions did not feel like interrogation. Jackie had always listened by building a place for the answer to stand.

When Zoe mentioned the archive, Jackie looked towards the bed.

"You brought something out."

Zoe stopped.

Jackie knew her too well.

"You keep checking under there," she said. "Not like you're scared something's hiding. Like you're scared it isn't."

Zoe pulled the backpack from behind the storage box.

She did not remove the folder or the drive. She opened the zip just far enough for Jackie to see the edge of the file and the black casing beneath it.

"I haven't looked," Zoe said.

"Why not?"

"Because what if it explains everything?"

Jackie considered that.

"What if it explains one thing and gives you twenty worse questions?"

"That's meant to help?"

"No. It's meant to be accurate."

Zoe closed the bag.

Jackie did not reach for it.

That mattered.

Helen had tried to take it. Mac had never asked what Zoe had brought back. Jackie was the first person who understood that the fact Zoe possessed something did not make it available to everyone who claimed to care about her.

"What happens now?" she asked.

Zoe told her about the grandmother.

About the flight Mac was arranging. About the person who would

collect her at the other end. About the address she had never seen and the relative nobody had mentioned until the day Mac needed somewhere to send her.

Jackie sat back against the bed.

"You don't believe she's real."

"I don't know what real means anymore."

"Fair."

"Mac chose all of it. The flight, the person meeting me, the house."

"And the people who took you know him."

"I don't know that."

"You think it."

Zoe looked at her.

Jackie raised one shoulder.

"You do the thing with your left eyebrow when you're leaving out the worst part."

"I do not."

"You just did it."

They stared at each other.

Then, as they had done hundreds of times in classrooms, bedrooms and message threads long after midnight, they reached the same conclusion without either needing to finish the sentence.

"We need another route," Zoe said.

"We need them to believe another route," Jackie corrected.

The plan began on the back of an old science worksheet.

Jackie drew three boxes.

"What do they know?"

"That I'm here. Maybe."

"Assume they do. What else?"

"Mac is moving me."

"Do they know when?"

"Not yet."

"Good. What can they see?"

Zoe looked towards the window.

The curtains had remained closed since she came home.

"Front door. Back gate. Anyone visiting."

"Phones," Jackie said. "Accounts. Searches, if they're good."

"You think they're watching all that?"

"I think people who steal children probably don't rely on luck."

She wrote SEE above the first box, FIND above the second and BELIEVE above the third.

Zoe watched her work.

This was how Jackie had survived her father. How she had got three smaller children washed and dressed before school after nights when no adult in the house could stand. She broke impossible things into jobs small enough to do.

By midday they had the shape of it.

The false route would lead away from the airport.

A late coach to the coast. An overnight crossing. A train beyond the port. Enough ordinary detail to survive a quick check and enough uncertainty to look like a plan made by frightened people in a hurry.

They assumed Zoe's old accounts might be watched, but using the house network could alert Helen, Brian or Mac. Jackie switched off the Wi-Fi on her phone and used mobile data instead.

Zoe logged into an old shared account they had once used for homework files.

She sent a message from herself to a second account they both knew:

Plan changed. Coach tonight. Same place we talked about. Don't reply.

They saved a route map in the shared cloud folder, added a screenshot of the coach timetable and created a draft note containing the ferry terminal, the departure time and a partial booking reference.

They opened the booking page but did not complete payment.

Jackie copied the coach number onto the science sheet, then wrote it again on the corner of an envelope downstairs where somebody searching the recycling might find it.

"If Helen or Brian find that, they'll tell Mac," Zoe said.

"That's the point."

"And if somebody comes through the house later?"

"It looks like we were careless."

"Too obvious."

"Obvious is fine if it looks accidental."

"That sounds like something from one of your stories."

"It is."

Jackie collected stories from the places she had lived after her siblings were separated. Things older children whispered after lights-out. Names adults used only when doors were closed. Rumours about men who found people, erased debts or left rooms full of bodies and no witnesses willing to explain them.

Most of the stories contradicted one another.

Jackie remembered all of them.

"The Reaper one?" Zoe asked.

"No. That one says never leave evidence. We're doing the opposite."

“Comforting.”

“I’m a very comforting person.”

“You threatened a Year Eight with a compass.”

“He stole your lunch.”

“You drew blood.”

“Barely.”

Zoe smiled despite herself.

Jackie smiled back, and for several minutes they were simply two girls wasting a Sunday over a ridiculous plan, arguing about whether a ferry terminal had vending machines and whether anybody over the age of thirty understood private messages.

Then footsteps sounded on the landing.

The smiles vanished at the same time.

Helen knocked.

“Jackie, your hour was over two hours ago.”

“We’re doing homework.”

“It’s Sunday.”

“We’re very committed.”

The handle moved against the chair.

“Open the door.”

Jackie swept the papers beneath Zoe’s duvet. Zoe pushed the backpack under the bed. They moved without speaking, each already doing the half of the job the other expected.

When Zoe pulled the chair away, Helen entered carrying two mugs of tea.

She looked from one girl to the other.

Her eyes paused on Jackie’s phone.

"You were told not to contact anyone," she said to Zoe.

"She contacted me," Jackie said.

"That is not clever."

"No," Jackie replied. "Clever would have been telling people Zoe was missing four days ago."

The words struck cleanly.

Helen's face lost colour.

Zoe expected anger. Instead Helen placed the mugs on the desk with care, as though the room had tilted and spilling tea would make it worse.

"You don't know what you're involved in," she said.

Jackie's expression changed.

Not into fear. Into recognition.

She had heard versions of that sentence before, from social workers, placement officers and adults who used secrecy as proof of importance.

"Neither do you," she said.

Helen looked at Zoe.

For one second, there was something in her face that might have become an apology.

Then it closed.

"Brian is taking you home now."

"I'll walk."

"No."

"Fine," Jackie said. "I'll go to the police station first."

Helen went still.

Jackie held her gaze.

"Zoe disappeared on Tuesday. School says family emergency. I've seen her now. You can either let me stay until she tells me what's happening, or I explain all of that to somebody who has to write it down."

"You wouldn't."

"I've been asking where she is for five days."

Brian appeared behind Helen.

His expression suggested he had heard enough.

"Give me the phone," he said.

"No."

"You are a child in my house."

"And Zoe is a missing child in your house."

The optimism adults often mistook for softness had left Jackie's face completely.

Brian looked at Helen.

For several seconds, they communicated without speaking.

Keeping Jackie inside and quiet was safer than forcing her into public.

"Until after ten," Helen said at last. "No calls. No messages. You stay in this room unless we ask you downstairs."

Jackie switched her phone to flight mode and placed it face up on the desk.

"Fine."

"Brian will take you home."

"I'll walk."

"After ten," Helen repeated.

Jackie smiled politely.

It was the smile she used on teachers when she had already decided

which rule she was going to break.

Helen left without taking the phone.

Shortly after four, Brian brought upstairs an envelope containing the itinerary Mac had emailed him to print.

He waited while Zoe opened it.

Inside were a boarding pass, travel instructions and a printed photograph of the man who would meet her after the flight.

Elias.

His expression in the photograph was neutral, almost tired. Mac had written a number on the back and one sentence beneath it:

He is harmless. Do exactly what he says.

Zoe read the sentence twice.

Brian remained in the doorway.

"The car comes at four fifteen tomorrow morning," he said. "You need to be ready."

"Who is driving?"

"Someone Mac trusts."

"Name?"

"I don't know."

Zoe held up the photograph.

"Does he?"

Brian's eyes moved away.

"Pack light."

He left.

Jackie waited until his steps reached the stairs, then took the papers from Zoe.

Departure before dawn. One direct flight. Arrival early afternoon in another country. A collector waiting beyond customs.

The information made the room feel smaller.

"They won't expect you to move that early if we make tonight look convincing," Jackie said.

"Or they'll expect exactly that because Mac arranged it."

"Mac knows. The people watching might not."

"Might."

"That's what plans are made of when adults won't tell you anything."

They revised everything.

The false coach left shortly before midnight. Jackie would leave the house after ten wearing Zoe's dark coat, hood up, with Zoe's spare school backpack. They were close enough in height and build for the coat, the darkness and distance to do the rest.

Jackie would walk to the stop on the main road, board the route towards the central coach station and remain visible long enough for anybody watching the house to follow.

The bag would contain old clothes, the copied coach number and a folded route to the ferry terminal.

Jackie would get off two stops before the station, cross through the shopping precinct and call Zoe from the all-night supermarket once she was certain nobody had followed her home.

The spare pay-as-you-go phone would remain with Zoe.

"And if someone does follow you?" Zoe asked.

"I go into the supermarket and call the police."

"You said the police might not help."

"I said we can't assume they know what they're looking at. A thirteen-year-old being followed by an adult is simple enough even for them."

"You're not doing it."

Jackie continued folding the route map.

"Jackie."

"Then you go."

"I can't."

"Exactly."

"This isn't one of your siblings. You don't have to—"

Jackie stopped folding.

The room changed.

Zoe wished the sentence back before she had finished saying it.

Jackie looked down at the paper in her hands.

"No," she said. "You're not."

"I didn't mean—"

"I know."

She smoothed the crease with her thumbnail.

"I couldn't keep them with me," she said. "That doesn't mean I stop showing up for people."

Zoe's throat tightened.

"You could get hurt."

"So could you."

"I already did."

Jackie looked at her then.

The optimism adults often mistook for softness was gone. Beneath it was the part of Jackie built in kitchens before dawn, in rooms where she listened for her father's footsteps and decided which child to move first.

"Then you know why I'm not leaving you to do this alone."

Neither spoke for a while.

Eventually Zoe said, "No paper with the real route."

"Agreed."

She made Jackie repeat it until every time, location and identifying detail was correct.

Four fifteen pickup.

Airport before six.

Direct flight after seven.

The arrival terminal.

The name and photograph of the collector.

The address where he was supposed to take her.

Jackie repeated the details once more without error.

"If I don't call when I reach the supermarket," she said, "you assume the decoy failed. You tell Helen the route is exposed and you don't get in the car."

"Helen will make me."

"Then scream. Break something. Run to a neighbour. Make it impossible to move you quietly."

"You make everything sound easy."

"No. I make it sound like steps. Easy is different."

They spent the remaining hours trying not to look at the clock.

They ate the biscuits Jackie had brought and watched half an episode of a comedy neither followed. Jackie repaired the broken zip on Zoe's pencil case with black thread from Helen's sewing tin. Zoe painted over the bright logo on the spare backpack so it would look more like the one she had carried from school.

At eight, Brian made them come downstairs for dinner.

He served pasta from a jar and watched Jackie too closely. Helen asked about school as though four days of disappearance and a secret international flight could be kept outside the kitchen by discussing a history assignment.

Jackie answered every question with exaggerated politeness.

When Helen asked whether she wanted more food, Jackie said yes and wrapped half of it in a napkin for later without thinking.

Zoe noticed.

Jackie noticed her noticing.

Neither mentioned the three children Jackie still fed in her head.

At nine forty-five, they returned upstairs.

Jackie changed into Zoe's coat. The sleeves were slightly short, but the hood shadowed her face. She put on the spare backpack and turned once in front of the mirror.

"Convincing?"

"You look like someone trying to steal my identity badly."

"Perfect, then."

Zoe tried to smile.

Jackie plugged the spare phone into the wall beside Zoe's bed.

"Leave it on," she said. "Don't message. Don't call unless I do first."

"Public place."

"All-night supermarket."

"If you're followed—"

"Police, noise, people."

"If you don't call—"

"The route is dead. You don't travel."

They had always finished each other's sentences.

That night it felt less like closeness than a way of making sure neither could pretend later that they had misunderstood.

Downstairs, Helen called that it was time.

Jackie opened the bedroom door, then stopped.

She turned back and held out her little finger.

It was something they had done on the first day they met, after Jackie told Zoe that promises made by adults were mostly paperwork and promises made by children needed witnesses.

Zoe hooked her finger around Jackie's.

"You call," she said.

"I call."

"No matter what."

Jackie's expression flickered.

Then the brightness returned, deliberate and brave.

"No matter what."

Jackie left through the back gate at six minutes past ten.

Zoe watched from the narrow gap between the curtains.

The coat and backpack made Jackie look enough like her at a distance to turn Zoe's stomach. She walked without hurrying, head down, one hand in the pocket where she had placed the false route.

At the end of the alley, she paused beneath the weak orange light and looked back.

Zoe raised two fingers against the glass.

Jackie did the same.

Then she turned the corner and disappeared.

Zoe remained at the window until the cold from the glass reached her

forehead.

The house settled around her. Pipes moved in the walls. Brian checked the back door. Helen carried mugs into the kitchen and left one untouched beside Zoe's place.

At ten thirty, Zoe sat on the floor with the spare phone in front of her.

At eleven, she told herself the bus was late.

At eleven fifteen, she told herself Jackie was making sure she had not been followed.

At eleven thirty, the phone remained silent.

In the car, Zoe looked down at her hands.

"She was supposed to call," she said. "That was the whole rule. Whatever happened, she called."

Elias kept his eyes on the road.

"You didn't know for certain the house was being watched."

"I knew it might be. That's why I sent her out."

"You made a plan together."

"I gave her the real route."

"Because she was the only person you trusted."

Zoe's fingers closed around the edge of her sleeve.

"Trust got her taken."

"Whoever was watching the house chose what happened after she left. You didn't."

"They wouldn't have had a reason if I hadn't brought her in."

Elias was quiet for several seconds.

"Jackie came because you had vanished," he said. "She stayed because she chose to."

"She was thirteen."

“So were you.”

He left the words where they were. He did not soften them into forgiveness she had not asked for.

The roadworks ended and the traffic dispersed across the open lanes.

“I kept waiting for the phone,” Zoe said. “Even after I knew it wasn’t going to ring.”

Elias glanced at her in the mirror.

“And by morning?”

Zoe looked towards the backpack at her feet.

“By morning, I had to assume the route was exposed,” she said. “What happened at the other end proved it.”